

The Chattanooga Guides Series

Weekend Hosting in Chattanooga: Choo Choo Edition

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Family and friends coming to town is exciting, but many of us can relate to the nervousness of trying to plan a weekend they will actually enjoy. On a recent occasion, I planned one of these visits around the Chattanooga Choo Choo as the focal point. It definitely leans touristy, so if that is not your taste, this might not be what you are looking for.

This area has a few strengths going for it:

Your people get to stay in the city itself.

You have access to a range of points of interest within walking distance.

There are plenty of photo opportunities.

The area can accommodate different tastes, but this post will focus primarily on restaurants and nightlife options. Some places may be referenced more than once since they fit into multiple categories.

By Topic.

Where to Stay

Beginning Your Day

Middle of the Day

Evening

Bonus

Where to Stay.

Your guests have the unique option of staying in a room at the Choo Choo itself, inside one of the train cars. Availability can be limited, so other strong options nearby include the Moxy Hotel, Kinley Hotel, and The Hotel Chalet.

My guests chose to stay at the Moxy, which is about a three minute walk to the Choo Choo. On the first floor, the Moxy also has a large bar and gathering area for guests to enjoy while making plans for the day or evening. It can also serve as your first stop if your plans are already set.

Now that you have chosen a place to stay, let's walk through options for beginning your day, filling the afternoon, and wrapping up the evening.

Beginning Your Day.

For the Up Before Breakfast Crowd.

Start your day with a caffeine fix from either [The Hot Chocolatier](#) or Mean Mug. Both offer a range of hot drinks and sweet treats to get things going. For a wider map of roasters, brunch cafes, and neighborhood shops across the metro, see the [Chattanooga coffee shops guide](#). If you are looking specifically for desserts around Chattanooga, check out our [dedicated guide](#).

Breakfast.

Once the rest of your group is awake and ready to break the fast, here are some walkable options:

Frothy Monkey, located inside the Choo Choo Plaza.

The Exchange, across the street at the Kinley Hotel, open seven days a week from 7am with coffee and baked goods in the morning that give way to cocktails and small plates by night.

Neidlov's Cafe and Bakery, for a less formal cafe experience with baked goods, sandwiches, and coffee.

Middle of the Day.

You likely already have [daytime plans](#), but if you need to fill some extra time, here are a few options in the Choo Choo area.

This is one of the more popular photo areas in Chattanooga. You can take photos at the Chattanooga sign, around the train cars, and inside the main hall, which sometimes features seasonal centerpieces such as a Christmas tree or even a pop up roller skating rink.

For those interested in art, there are two nearby galleries:

Hart Gallery Tennessee, which sells art and crafts made by local homeless and other nontraditional artists.

Gallery 1401, a nearby modern art gallery.

You can also take a whiskey tour at Chattanooga Whiskey. Tours last about an hour and walk you through their distilling and bottling process while explaining differences between batches. A flight of whiskey is included with your ticket.

For something lighthearted, get your caricature drawn at HartsFartsy Caricature Couch. Past visitors describe the artist as engaging and entertaining, and you leave with one of a kind art.

If your visit lands during baseball season, the Chattanooga Lookouts now play at [Erlanger Park](#), their new ballpark in the South Broad District that opened in April 2026. It is a short drive south of the Choo Choo, or a longer walk down the Tennessee Riverwalk, which runs right through the stadium grounds. Even without a game on the schedule, the walk down and back is an easy way to fill an afternoon.

Evening.

Dinner.

Here are three recommended dinner spots within walking distance, followed by a bonus option I have not personally tried but may be worth checking out.

Nic and Norman's is a burger and Southern comfort food restaurant with a full bar, run by filmmaker Greg Nicotero and actor Norman Reedus. It is located inside the Choo Choo.

Feed Table and Tavern is a local favorite known for interesting menu options like chili pot roast or grass fed sloppy joes. It has a lively atmosphere and a full bar.

Elsie's Daughter offers French Belgian cuisine with a bit of Appalachia. Main courses may include paprika roasted half chicken or short rib ragu.

Bonus pick: **Bluegrass Grill**, a highly rated Southern style restaurant serving both breakfast and dinner, though I have not personally been.

Dessert.

If you have left room after dinner, there is [Clumpies](#), a homegrown ice cream shop just across the street from the Choo Choo that is known for its process and rotating flavors.

Around the corner from Clumpies is Insomnia Cookies, where you can sample warm cookies from the day's menu.

After Dinner Non Alcohol Options.

The Comedy Catch, located at the Choo Choo, may have a show running. Check their calendar for tickets. We also have guides to [live music](#) and [performing arts](#) for more options.

[The Signal](#) and Barrelhouse Ballroom are nearby music venues that feature both regional and national acts. Check their calendars for live performances.

Cocktail and Happy Hour.

For an evening cocktail, you have several choices. I recommend the back outdoor bar at Gate 11 Distillery when the weather cooperates. They distill their own spirits on site, including a gin that has won awards worldwide, and make excellent handcrafted cocktails. The Gimlet or Mule are both strong choices.

Elsie's Daughter is also known for its cocktails, and Stir offers a lively atmosphere.

If you are up for a short trip into downtown, [Iris](#) opened in early 2026 on the 11th floor of the Waymark Hotel, inside a restored 1927 bank building. You get signature cocktails and one of the higher skyline views in the city. Downstairs, the building's old bank vault is now a hidden speakeasy called The Vault.

If you prefer beer, there are three breweries in or near the Choo Choo:

TailGate Brewery next door.

Five Wits across the street.

Wanderlinger Brewing on Station Street.

It is good to have options.

Nightlife.

Many of the places mentioned above become lively as the evening progresses, so do not feel pressured to keep moving if you have found your spot. However, if you are looking for additional nightlife options, Station Street next to the Choo Choo offers the following.

Backstage Bar has a wide whiskey menu, rotating draft beers, live music, and a strong patio scene. It is open until 2am on Fridays and Saturdays.

The Boneyard hosts nontraditional events such as Drag Night and Goth Night in addition to regular music events.

Reagan's Retro Bar has more of a club atmosphere. If you are looking for dancing and DJs, this is your spot.

Bonus.

You have two game stop options during your visit. There is a dedicated arcade where you can pop in and play. At The Boneyard, you can also check out the pinball machines and see if you can set the night's high score.

The goal of this post was to make hosting easier for those welcoming guests from near or far who want to enjoy a variety of Chattanooga establishments in a walkable area. If this helped, share it with a friend or on social media.

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